day working week, while every other Eastern Bloc country continued with the sixday model. Also striking were figures showing the high proportion of female workers; on a world scale, East Germany sat in second place with 47 per cent of women in employment, next to the Soviet Union with 51.7 per cent. There was occasional reportage of German-German relations, such as Ulbricht's proposal that West German Chancellor Dr Kurt Klesinger and Willi Stoph should meet to discuss steps toward cooperation between the two countries. He embellished these ideas at the opening session of the seventh SED Party Congress in April 1967, where he said the two men should be accompanied by experts to formulate agreements. However, his insistence that such a meeting be tied to discussion of his long-demanded objectives such as the recognition of existing borders, disarmament of both Germanys, and the mutual renunciation of nuclear weapons, led nowhere.

In contrast, Honecker's performance at the conference looked narrowminded and inflammatory. In a twenty-five-page speech, he delivered a stinging attack on China's leaders, accusing them of poisonous nationalism and fostering a personality cult around Mao Tse Tung. Then he took a swipe at West German prosperity by posing the question as to what might have become of the 'capitalist gentlemen' if in 1945 the Eastern sector of Germany had had 120 blast furnaces and the West had only four instead of vice versa? 'The truth is,' he cried, 'that our people by their own strength and with active support, mainly from our Soviet friends, cleared away the rubble left by the Second World War, overcame squalor and chaos and created a modern socialist industrial state.'13 Such comments sat uneasily alongside Ulbricht's 'overture' to Chancellor Klesinger. But here the unhappiness ran deeper, Honecker – like Brezhnev – was troubled by Ulbricht's approaches to Bonn. As he continued his sharp speeches, the demarcation of the GDR and closer ties with Moscow became a running theme. In a reference to the West's desire for reunification, Honecker barked that 'no matter how much our adversaries in West Germany clamour, they can no longer turn back the wheel of history'.

We stand firmly by our socialist fatherland, our GDR. And let it be clearly said from this rostrum of the seventh congress to